

Nick Sannen

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Internationally experienced commercial professional with a strong background in partnership management, high-value sales and distributor development. A career spent at the top of cycling and motorsport, from right-hand to a MotoGP World Champion and to one of Belgium's greatest cyclists, through ultra-premium sales, to founding and building two professional gravel teams from scratch. A strategic relationship builder with an entrepreneurial mindset, effective across marketing, sales and operations, and most at home with full ownership of a project.

KEY SKILLS & EXPERTISE

Partnership Management - High-Value Sales - Sponsorship Acquisition - Distributor Development - B2B Relationship Management - Contract Negotiation - Team Building - Athlete Management - Budget Management - Race & Event Logistics - Content Strategy - Storytelling - Brand Positioning - Marketing & Communications - Event Activations - Trade Shows

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

Foodmaker X Gravel King 2026-Present

Founder & GM

Founder and general manager of a professional gravel team built from a blank sheet, with end-to-end accountability for commercial, brand, roster and race programme.

- Created the team from nothing and runs it day to day, accountable for strategy, commercial, content, sport and budget.
- Owns the full sponsor portfolio, securing and managing partnerships with international brands as their senior point of contact.
- Directs the entire content and communication programme, from team storytelling and launch announcements to season-long brand positioning.
- Leads rider recruitment and contract negotiation, building a competitive squad and the support structure around it.
- Brought an established cycling community, TNS, into the team, converting an engaged audience into measurable reach and value for partners.

Classified x Rose 2023-2026

Team / Athlete Manager & Founder

Founded and ran a professional gravel team for drivetrain brand Classified, owning it end to end across three seasons while acting as its commercial engine and lead brand ambassador.

- Built the team from the ground up and managed every operational and sporting decision across three seasons.
- Secured and managed the sponsorships and commercial partnerships that underpinned the team's financial stability and growth.
- Owned athlete contracts, logistics, race planning and performance support as the riders' primary manager.
- Directed marketing and communications, building visibility and credibility with audiences, media and the trade.
- Represented Classified to dealers and distributors and fed market intelligence back to the marketing and product teams.

Classified 2022-2026

Athlete Manager & Event Manager

Owned athlete relations and the full event and activation calendar for Classified, running the brand from the paddock through to the point of sale.

- Single point of contact for the brand's athletes, turning the relationship into content and visibility aligned to brand strategy.

- Planned and delivered events, trade shows and activations end to end, from venue booking to on-site execution.
- Owned sales logistics and on-site sales operations at trade shows, consistently hitting commercial targets.
- Drove distributor activation by aligning brand presence with local sales objectives in each market.

Paul Sannen bv 2008-2021

Manager / Partnerships & Operations

Thirteen years running partnerships and ultra-premium sales for a business operating where elite motorsport, cycling and high-end automotive meet.

- Led commercial negotiations with international brands and private clients, brokering partnerships across elite motorsport and cycling.
- Sold luxury vehicles at the top of the market, handling individual transactions above EUR 500,000 on the strength of discreet, trust-based relationships.
- Served as senior commercial contact for international stakeholders, aligning brand objectives with business opportunities.
- Built and held long-term B2B relationships with sponsors, partners and rights holders across multiple markets for over a decade.

Nicky Hayden, MotoGP 2011-2017

Personal Assistant to a MotoGP World Champion

Six seasons as the trusted right-hand to MotoGP World Champion Nicky Hayden, inside the top tier of world motorcycle racing.

- Managed the rider's schedule, logistics and commitments through demanding back-to-back race weekends across an international Grand Prix calendar.
- Acted as front-line contact for sponsors, partners and VIP guests in the paddock, keeping high-value commercial relationships warm.
- Represented the rider and his partners to customers and fans in a high-visibility, high-scrutiny environment.

Tom Boonen 2010-2011

Personal Assistant to a Cycling Great

Trusted personal support to Tom Boonen, a former world champion, multiple Classics winner and one of the biggest names in Belgian cycling.

- Managed day-to-day commitments, schedule, logistics and access around a high-profile professional athlete through the racing season.

ADDITIONAL

Languages: Dutch (native), English (very good), French (basic), German (notions)

Licences: Driving licences B, C & CE

Personal Interests: Cycling, gravel, running, motorsport

Personal: Belgian, based in Meerhout. Born 08/03/1985.

EDUCATION & QUALIFICATIONS

Physical Education and Sport - Rozenberg, Mol (1997-2005)

Driving Licences B, C & CE - car, truck and truck-with-trailer categories